STANDARD IQ · PARTNER PROPOSAL

Subscriptions & Digital Distribution

How Standard IQ turns a 3-million-user network into a paying readership, and how every edition reaches each subscriber through a personal, secure link.

October 2026 · Draft for discussion · Prices in US dollars

THE PRODUCT

A 124-page monthly that Africa's quality leaders already read

Each edition is built around deadlines and decisions: transitions, the institutions behind them, and what businesses must do next.



FROM THE PUBLISHER

Standard IQ

Quality belongs in the public conversation

Standards help determine who can compete, what people can trust and whether Africa's industrial ambitions become dependable results.

Norman Ndlovu

Chief Executive Officer
Afrolso

An entrepreneur can have a good product and a willing buyer, yet still struggle to complete an order. The nearest suitable testing laboratory may be prohibitively far away, or a consignment may face further assessment because the evidence accompanying it is not accepted at its destination. For a small business, the resulting costs and delays can put a hard-won commercial relationship at risk. Consumers depend on these same systems when they need assurance that a product is safe and will perform as promised.

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THE STANDARD IQ DOSSIER

Khaled Soufi: widening the influence of developing countries

The Egyptian standards chief has made broader participation a priority of his ISO presidency. For African institutions, influence will depend on the expertise they can sustain throughout the drafting process.

Standard IQ Editorial Desk

Khaled Soufi. Portrait supplied by Standard IQ.

Khaled Soufi took office as ISO President on 1 January 2026 with a commitment to give developing countries a stronger voice in shaping international standards. His three-year term brings the chairman of the Egyptian Organization for Standardization into a global governance role whose priorities include helping national institutions contribute more effectively to the technical decisions that affect their economies.

Soufi's professional background spans engineering, quality management and standards

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IQ BRIEF GLOBAL

Environmental transition follows its own dates

Organisations using ISO 14001 and ISO 9001 can coordinate preparation, but their transition deadlines differ.

Standard IQ Editorial Desk

Organisations managing quality and environmental certification together face two transition calendars. Under Global ACI's applicable arrangements, existing ISO 14001:2015 certification must transition by 30 April 2029—five months before the ISO 9001 deadline.

The environmental timetable, announced on 14 September 2026, requires accreditation bodies to be ready to assess ISO 14001:2026 by 31 October 2026. Accredited certification bodies must submit their transition declarations and supporting information by 31 January 2027. Accreditation decisions on those transitions are due by 30 April 2027.

From 31 October 2027, new and initial accredited environmental management system certifications may be issued only against ISO 14001:2026. These requirements cover Global ACI Multilateral Recognition Arrangement signatories and their accredited certification bodies within the relevant scope.

Shared processes can make coordinated preparation worthwhile. Internal audits, management reviews and staff training may support both transitions, provided each standard's requirements receive adequate attention.

Organisations should agree assessment arrangements with their certification body early enough to accommodate the environmental deadline. A combined management system does not make the two timetables interchangeable.

124
pages in the Oct–Nov 2026 edition

54
African markets in scope

12
editions a year, live on the 5th

THE VALUE

Subscribers pay for deadlines, access and judgement, not just articles

Deadlines they can't miss

ISO 14001:2015 certificates must move to ISO 14001:2026 by 30 April 2029. ISO 9001 and ISO/IEC 17024 transitions follow their own dates.

Practical guidance

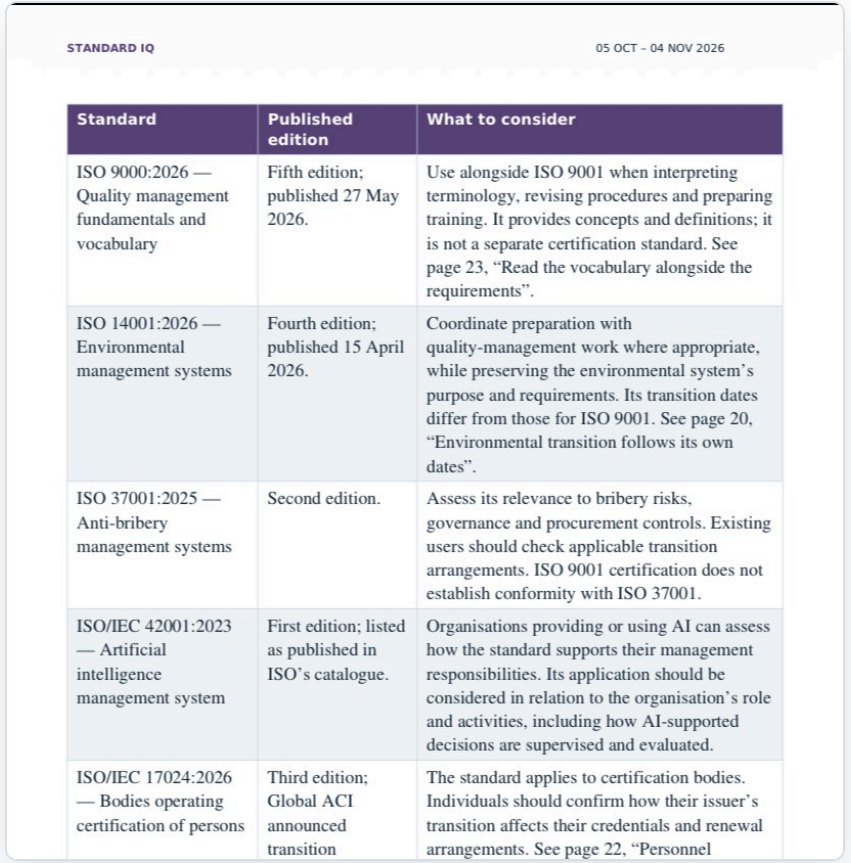
Tables like "what to consider" for each new standard turn news into action for quality managers.

Access to decision-makers

Dossiers on the ISO President, ARSO and the AU Commission. Readers can't get this view anywhere else.

Independence

"Informed. Independent. ISO Smart." Clear labels on all paid content keep that promise credible.



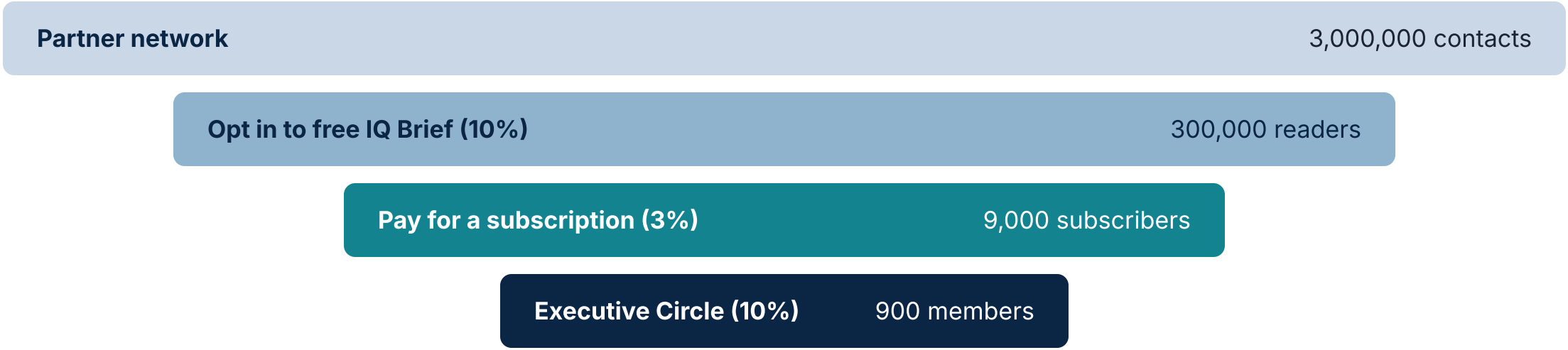
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Standard	Published edition	What to consider
ISO 9000:2026 — Quality management fundamentals and vocabulary	Fifth edition; published 27 May 2026.	Use alongside ISO 9001 when interpreting terminology, revising procedures and preparing training. It provides concepts and definitions; it is not a separate certification standard. See page 23, “Read the vocabulary alongside the requirements”.
ISO 14001:2026 — Environmental management systems	Fourth edition; published 15 April 2026.	Coordinate preparation with quality-management work where appropriate, while preserving the environmental system’s purpose and requirements. Its transition dates differ from those for ISO 9001. See page 20, “Environmental transition follows its own dates”.
ISO 37001:2025 — Anti-bribery management systems	Second edition.	Assess its relevance to bribery risks, governance and procurement controls. Existing users should check applicable transition arrangements. ISO 9001 certification does not establish conformity with ISO 37001.
ISO/IEC 42001:2023 — Artificial intelligence management system	First edition; listed as published in ISO’s catalogue.	Organisations providing or using AI can assess how the standard supports their management responsibilities. Its application should be considered in relation to the organisation’s role and activities, including how AI-supported decisions are supervised and evaluated.
ISO/IEC 17024:2026 — Bodies operating certification of persons	Third edition; Global ACI announced transition	The standard applies to certification bodies. Individuals should confirm how their issuer’s transition affects their credentials and renewal arrangements. See page 22, “Personnel

THE MODEL

From 3 million contacts to about 9,000 paying subscribers

This is the base case. Everyone gets something free; a focused group pays for the full edition and alerts.



Opt-in comes first: WhatsApp only allows messages to people who agreed to hear from Standard IQ. All rates are assumptions to be tested in the pilot.

PRICING

Four individual plans, from free to $29 a month

Prices shown are for Band A markets such as South Africa. Band B and Band C markets pay half or less (next slide).

FREE

IQ Brief

$0

always free, every market

- Weekly headlines on a WhatsApp Channel and by email
- 3 full articles a month
- Edition cover and contents page

For the whole partner network: this is the funnel

STARTER

Student & Early Career

$2

per month · $1 in Bands B and C

- Full monthly edition
- Archive access
- Deadline alerts for 2 standards

Students, trainee auditors, junior quality staff

MOST POPULAR

Professional

$6

per month · from $1.50 in Band C

- Full edition and full archive
- Weekly IQ Brief, full version on WhatsApp
- Deadline alerts for every standard you follow
- "Ask the desk": 1 question a month

Quality managers, auditors, consultants

PREMIUM

Executive Circle

$29

per month · from $12 in Band C

- Everything in Professional
- Quarterly closed-door virtual roundtable
- Member directory and curated introductions
- Watermarked PDF downloads
- 20% off Standard IQ events

CEOs, heads of standards bodies, directors

FAIR FOR AFRICA

Three price bands, so a reader in Kampala pays what they can afford

Each country is placed in a band by its World Bank income group. The band is set by the reader's phone number and payment country.

Monthly price (annual)	Band A · upper-middle income	Band B · lower-middle income	Band C · low income
Example markets	South Africa, Botswana, Namibia	Nigeria, Kenya, Egypt, Ghana, Morocco	Ethiopia, Uganda, Malawi, Mozambique, DRC
Student & Early Career	$2 ($20)	$1 ($10)	$1 ($10)
Professional	**$6 ($60)**	**$3 ($30)**	**$1.50 ($15)**
Executive Circle	$29 ($290)	$19 ($190)	$12 ($120)
Team seat, per year	$48	$24	$12
Institution, per year	from $2,400	from $1,200	from $600
Professional in local currency	R99	KES 390 · ₦4,500 · EGP 149	set at about $1.50 locally

Executive prices drop less because senior leaders' incomes vary less between countries. Local amounts are indicative, set at launch at today's exchange rates.

FAIR FOR AFRICA

Paying should be as easy as reading

Pay the way Africa pays

M-Pesa, MTN MoMo, Airtel Money, cards, debit orders and EFT. Renewal reminders arrive on WhatsApp with a one-tap pay link.

Prices that don't jump

Subscribers keep their local price for 12 months. New-subscriber prices are reviewed every 6 months, not on every currency move.

No lock-in

Monthly plans cancel any time by replying STOP. Annual plans give 2 months free for those who can pay upfront.

Sponsor-a-Reader

Companies, standards bodies and development partners fund seats for small businesses and students. Sponsors are thanked in each edition.

Less than one standard

A year of Professional in Band A costs $60. One ISO standard document costs over 100 Swiss francs.

Free stays useful

The free IQ Brief keeps the key deadlines open to everyone, in every market, at no cost.

TEAMS & INSTITUTIONS

Organisations buy seats, which makes revenue steadier

Plan	Who	Price
Team	5–49 staff, managed by one admin	$48 / $24 / $12 per seat / year
Organisation	50+ staff, single invoice, usage report	$36 / $18 / $9 per seat / year
Institution	Standards bodies, regulators, universities: unlimited staff	from $2,400 / $1,200 / $600 a year

Companies pay by invoice and renew yearly. An admin dashboard adds or removes staff by email or phone number, and every seat gets the same personal-link delivery. Prices shown for Bands A / B / C.

GETTING SUBSCRIBERS

Signing up takes under two minutes, without leaving the phone

1

Discover

Partner message, WhatsApp Channel post, LinkedIn or a QR code in the edition.

2

Opt in

Reader replies **JOIN** on WhatsApp, or taps the sign-up link. Consent is recorded.

3

Verify

One-time code to the phone; email added for receipts and backup delivery.

4

Choose plan

Pick a plan and the standards to follow (ISO 9001, 14001, 45001, 27001…).

5

Pay

Card, debit order, M-Pesa or bank transfer through Paystack, Flutterwave or Stripe.

6

Welcome

Payment confirmed automatically; the current edition's personal link arrives in seconds.

Every partner sign-up carries a referral code, so revenue share is calculated automatically.



DISTRIBUTION

How each edition reaches every subscriber on the 5th

1 · Publish

Editorial uploads the final edition to the content system and schedules release.

2 · Match

System selects every active subscriber and the articles that fit their chosen standards.

3 · Personalise

A unique, signed link is created for each subscriber and each edition.

4 · Send

Buzz360 sends each message through Meta's WhatsApp API at 07:00, with email as backup.

5 · Read & measure

Reader opens the edition in the browser. Opens and reading time feed reports.

What the subscriber sees on WhatsApp (example)

```
Good morning Thandi, the Oct–Nov edition of Standard IQ is
ready.
This month: ISO 14001 transition dates, and the ISO President
on Africa's voice.
[ Read now ] button opens the personal link
Reply LINK for a new link · STOP to unsubscribe
```

Technology, all off the shelf

- Buzz360, connected to Meta's official WhatsApp Cloud API
- Subscriber database and link service (for example Supabase / Postgres)
- Payments: Paystack, Flutterwave, M-Pesa and Stripe
- Email backup: Brevo or Postmark · Secure web reader for the edition

META'S WHATSAPP API

Meta's official API can deliver every edition, one subscriber at a time

The WhatsApp Business Platform (Cloud API) lets our system send messages and receive replies automatically. It has no "publish to everyone" button, so the system sends one message per subscriber, in minutes.

What the API does

- **Approved templates**: a pre-approved message with the cover image and the reader's name filled in
- **Personal "Read now" button**: each message carries that subscriber's own link
- **Reports back**: delivered, read and failed statuses, plus replies like LINK, STOP and JOIN
- **In-chat forms** (WhatsApp Flows) for sign-up and choosing standards to follow
- **Speed**: thousands of messages in a few minutes, within the number's daily limit

What it doesn't do

- **No broadcast to everyone at once**: one send per person
- **No API for WhatsApp Channels**: Channel posts are made by hand in the app
- **No in-chat payments in South Africa**: subscribers pay through a payment link
- **No messages without opt-in**: every contact must have agreed to hear from Standard IQ
- **No unofficial bulk tools**: automating WhatsApp Web gets the number banned

INTEGRATION WITH BUZZ360

Buzz360 sends the messages; our subscription system decides who gets what

Edition published
Editorial uploads it on the 5th

›

Subscription system
Master record: who paid, plan, band, personal links

›

Buzz360
Sends each template through the API

›

Meta Cloud API
Delivers to WhatsApp

›

Subscriber
Taps "Read now"

↶ Reports and replies flow back: delivered · read · failed · LINK · STOP · JOIN

Questions to confirm with Buzz360

1. Are you an official Meta partner on the Cloud API? Whose WhatsApp Business account holds the number?
2. Can we send approved templates by API with a personal link button for each person?
3. Do you forward delivery reports and replies to our system?
4. What do you charge on top of Meta's per-message fees?
5. Where is subscriber data stored, and is it POPIA-compliant?

Why the subscriber list stays with us

The subscription system is the master record, and Buzz360 only delivers. If the provider or the partnership changes, Standard IQ keeps every subscriber, payment and link.

Paid readers on WhatsApp cost little; free readers must go by Channel and email

Reported South African rate, from Oct 2026	Per message
Utility (account and service updates)	$0.0076 · R0.12
Marketing (promotions, newsletters)	$0.0379 · R0.62
Authentication (one-time codes)	$0.0076 · R0.12

Monthly sending cost	Estimate
9,000 paid subscribers × 6 messages	$410 to $2,050
300,000 free readers × 4 briefs on the API	**≈ $45,500**
Same free readers via Channel + email	**≈ $0**

Meta charges on delivery, by country and type, and may treat "your edition is ready" as marketing, so budget at the higher rate. Rates are from press reports (Briefly, Oct 2026) and must be checked on Meta's pricing page.

Sending limits grow with quality

A new number starts with a limited number of people per day. Meta raises the limit in steps (roughly 1,000, then 10,000, then 100,000, then unlimited) while quality stays high. Reaching the full partner base takes weeks, which suits a rollout in waves.

Set-up before the first send

- Meta business verification
- A dedicated number and an approved display name
- Approved message templates
- Recorded opt-in for every contact

A personal link instead of a PDF, so forwarding doesn't give the edition away

ANATOMY OF A LINK (EXAMPLE ADDRESS)

`iq.standardiq.com/r/K7M2QX`

The code is unique to **one subscriber** and **one edition**. It is signed by the server, so it can't be guessed or edited, and it can be switched off instantly if the subscription ends.

Plain PDFs get forwarded into WhatsApp groups within hours, and then nobody needs to subscribe. The PDF stays a perk for the Executive Circle, watermarked.

Two devices per subscriber

A third device triggers a one-time code to the subscriber's own phone, so a forwarded link doesn't open.

Visible watermark

Each page shows the reader's name and the last digits of their number, which discourages screenshots and sharing.

Self-service

Reply LINK for a fresh link; links stay valid for the edition's month and archive access continues while subscribed.

At most six messages a month, each one useful

When	Message	Who gets it
5th, 07:00	New edition, personal link	All paid
Every Tuesday	Weekly IQ Brief	Paid by WhatsApp message; free by Channel and email
As needed	Deadline alert for a followed standard	Paid
3 days before renewal	Renewal reminder with pay link	Mobile-money payers
Day 12 of trial	"Your trial ends in 2 days"	Trial users

Target: monthly churn below 5%, and at least 60% of each edition's links opened within 7 days.

Failed payment

Three automatic retries over 7 days, each with a WhatsApp nudge and pay link. Access stays open during this grace period.

Paused, not deleted

After the grace period, access pauses but preferences and history are kept. Paying again restores everything at once.

Win-back

30 days after a lapse: one message with the latest headlines and a single-month offer.

UNIT ECONOMICS

Every band covers its costs, even at $1.50 a month

Professional, per subscriber per month	Band A	Band B	Band C
Subscription price	**6.00**	**3.00**	**1.50**
Payment fees (≈3.5%; more on small mobile-money payments)	−0.21	−0.11	−0.08
WhatsApp messages (6, 6 and 4 sends)	−0.05 to −0.23	−0.05 to −0.23	−0.03 to −0.15
Email, hosting and secure reader	−0.06	−0.06	−0.06
Partner revenue share (30%, example)	−1.80	−0.90	−0.45
Left for the publisher (USD)	**3.70–3.88**	**1.70–1.88**	**0.76–0.88**

WhatsApp ranges use the reported South African utility and marketing rates as a guide; other countries' rates differ. Annual billing cuts payment fees further.

REVENUE SCENARIOS

The base case reaches about $62,000 a month in subscriptions

Monthly figures	Conservative	Base	Optimistic
Opt-in rate from 3M contacts	5%	10%	15%
Free readers	150,000	300,000	450,000
Paid conversion of free readers	2%	3%	4%
Professional subscribers (average $4.35)	2,700	8,100	16,200
Executive Circle members (average $23.30)	300	900	1,800
Individual revenue	$18,700	$56,200	$112,400
Teams & institutions	10 · $2,000	30 · $6,000	60 · $12,000
Total gross per month	**$20,700**	**$62,200**	**$124,400**
Total gross per year	**$0.25M**	**$0.75M**	**$1.49M**

Averages assume subscribers split 50% Band A, 40% Band B and 10% Band C. Lower prices in Bands B and C should lift conversion; the pilot will test this. Figures are gross, before fees, messaging and partner share; advertising comes on top.

Agree five terms, then pilot with 50,000 users

Terms to agree with the partner

- **Revenue share**, calculated on net revenue and tracked by referral code
- **Subscriber relationship** stays with Standard IQ; partner gets monthly reports
- **Messaging costs**: who pays for the opt-in campaign and ongoing sends
- **Consent and data protection** under POPIA, Nigeria's NDPA and Kenya's DPA
- **Term and exclusivity**, with minimum performance targets

Month 1 · Build

Confirm Buzz360 runs on the Cloud API. Meta business verification and templates. Build sign-up, payments, links and reader.

Month 2 · Pilot

Opt-in campaign to 50,000 partner users. 14-day trials; test the three price bands and conversion in each.

Month 3 · Launch

Roll out to the full network in weekly waves; start selling team and institution plans.

Informed. Independent. Delivered to every subscriber, personally.

Decisions needed from the partner: revenue share, who covers messaging costs, and a pilot start date.